



A fiery blast rocks one of the World Trade Center towers in New York City after a passenger jet slammed into it on Tuesday. Both buildings collapsed to the ground. PHOTO BY SPENCER PLATT / GETTY IMAGES

America Under Attack

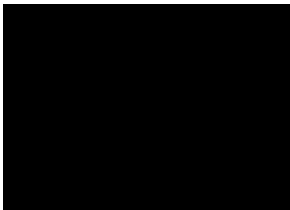
IT WAS PERHAPS the nation's bloodiest day, replayed again and again on every television screen. The jet crashes that destroyed the twin towers of New York's World Trade Center — the first at 8:45 a.m. Tuesday, the next at 9:03 — began a nightmare that would include an attack on the Pentagon, an airline crash in Pennsylvania and a president's vow to punish those responsible. Officials were not forthcoming with casualty estimates. But as the toll rose, it was apparent that Sept. 11, 2001, could eclipse any other disaster in national memory: the attack on Pearl Harbor, the casualties of D-Day, the Civil War carnage at Antietam.

"Freedom itself was attacked this morning," President Bush said. As smoke billowed from the Trade Center towers, workplace of 50,000 people, a third hijacked plane slammed into the Pentagon and a fourth crashed southeast of Pittsburgh. Manhattan, its cityscape altered forever, was evacuated, as were government buildings around the nation, including the Capitol, the White House and the S.C. State House. At Pearl Harbor in 1941, about 2,400 died; in the Johnstown Flood in Pennsylvania in 1889, more than 2,200; in

the Galveston, Texas, hurricane in 1900, about 6,000; at Antietam in Maryland in 1862, more than 4,700 soldiers. They were acts of nature and acts of war. But Tuesday's disaster was quickly termed an act of terrorism. "Today, our nation saw evil," Bush told the nation. He asked people to pray for the families of the victims and quoted the Book of Psalms: "And I pray they will be comforted by a power greater than any of us, spoken through the ages in Psalm 23. 'Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I fear no evil, for you are with me.'" — From staff and wire reports



TIMELINE
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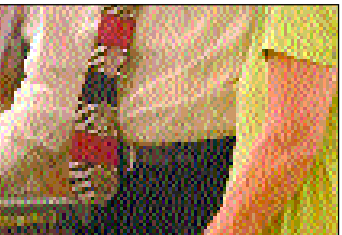
NIGHTMARE
Terrorists plunge hijacked planes into the World Trade Center towers in New York and the Pentagon.
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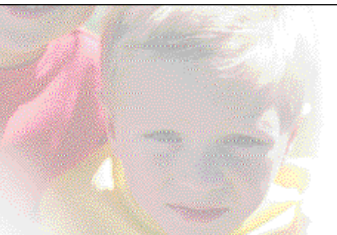
NEW YORK
New Yorkers react with disbelief: 'This is the most horrifying thing I've ever experienced.'
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WASHINGTON
The toll at the Pentagon is 'extensive.' Some lawmakers say U.S. intelligence network has atrophied.
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IN S.C.
South Carolinians react with shock, anger, worry and compassion for victims of the attacks.
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CHILDREN
How do you explain the tragic events to children? Here are some tips on how to approach each age group.
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